

By Women for Women for the Health of our Nation During WWII

The U.S. Cadet Nurse Corps (USCNC) was conceived by women, (Nursing leaders) administered by women and comprised of 180,000 young women who joined from 1943 to 1945.

Congresswoman, Frances Payne Bolton introduced the bill that established the USCNC. Lucile Petry directed the new program, and appointed twenty-five nurse consultants who administered the program in over 1200 Hospitals across the nation. Jean Henderson was the liaison to the Office of War Information (OWI) and the resultant recruitment program is acknowledged to be the most successful ever run by the government.

- The USCNC prevented the US health care system from collapsing. This would have left our nation vulnerable to unchecked illnesses; had a demoralizing and disastrous effect on our citizenry, and our wounded warriors.
- By enlisting in the USCNC, and staffing the hospitals, graduate nurses were then able to join the Armed services, and essential public health nurses could remain on the home front to provide care and critical immunizations to the workers in the country's burgeoning war industries.
- The Cadets confronted by epidemics of communicable diseases: Infantile Paralysis (Polio) and other infectious illnesses such as Tuberculosis and scarlet fever. They provided care and saved lives while risking their own. Some Cadets were casualties of these diseases.
- A significant number of nurses who were already in training in 1943 joined the "Corps." and upon graduation, in 1943 and 1944 went into the Army or Navy. Some went overseas, while others worked in Veteran hospitals.
- When a bill to draft nurses was being considered in 1945, over 10,000 graduates of the US Cadet Nurse Corps answered the call - negating the need for the draft.
- The 124,000 graduates of the USCNC provided nursing care to our nation's citizens for an average of twenty-eight years.